Peace and Violence in the Nineteenth Century

The Belief Files Case File 008 Historical investigation and biblical assessment Beyond the Message | Prepared for Jamie Dennis | November 8, 2026

Investigation summary

How should a Christian investigate violence in a movement that claims to restore the church of Jesus Christ? The first obligation is to tell the truth about the people who suffered. Early Latter-day Saints experienced real persecution. Some Latter-day Saints also threatened, dispossessed, and killed other people. Those statements concern different events and responsibilities; neither cancels the other.

This case follows the supplied research packet into Missouri, early Utah, the preaching called blood atonement, and the Mountain Meadows Massacre. It then examines the evidence for responsibility and the later acknowledgment of wrongdoing. The packet provides the starting questions. Selected published records, archival descriptions, current LDS explanations, and recorded Native perspectives supply additional checks. This is a focused investigation, not a complete history of every nineteenth-century conflict. [1]

The most important distinction is between establishing a crime and establishing every person's part in it. Uncertainty about a particular superior's knowledge does not make the killing of civilians uncertain. Conversely, proof that local leaders ordered violence does not automatically prove a secret order from every higher leader.

This case evaluates conduct, authority, and salvation teaching against Scripture from the project's evangelical and Trinitarian Christian perspective. Misconduct alone does not settle every religious claim.

The claim under investigation

The Church's peace-and-violence essay presents peacemaking as central to LDS teaching, recognizes persecution of early members, and acknowledges violence committed by members. It supplies historical context while rejecting that context as an excuse. That is a more accurate starting point than saying the Church simply denies its violent history. [2]

Doctrine and Covenants 98:16 commands believers to renounce war and proclaim peace. The surrounding section also addresses endurance under injury, defense, war, and forgiveness. Quoting verse 16 alone would conceal that broader framework. The existence of a peace command establishes a stated standard; it does not establish how faithfully any community followed it. [3]

The investigation asks three related questions:

- What do the surviving sources establish about particular episodes of persecution and violence?
- What can be attributed to individuals, local leadership, wider institutions, and particular teachings?
- Do the teachings and actions examined here agree with the New Testament account of Christian conduct and Christ's sacrifice?

These are tests of claims and conduct. A present-day LDS friend is not personally responsible for crimes committed before that friend's lifetime.

How this investigation weighs evidence

A dated order can establish an instruction. A sermon report can establish published teaching, subject to its transmission. A later deposition can establish what its speaker said under questioning, without making every recollection accurate. An institution's modern statement is direct evidence of its present position, but remains a later interpretation of an earlier event.

Five questions guide the reading: Who produced the source? When? What could that person actually know? What interests might shape the account?

What independent evidence supports or challenges it? The same questions apply to a defender, a critic, an accused participant, and a witness whose community was blamed.

Source numbers identify the register at the end. Historical reconstruction and this case's moral or theological reasoning remain distinguishable. Confidence labels describe the strength of a particular conclusion; they are not numerical probabilities or substitutes for a full archival investigation.

The historical timeline

Date	Record or event	Investigative significance
1838	Danite activity and the Missouri conflict; Boggs's October 27 order; the October 30 attack at Hawn's Mill.	Read evidence of persecution alongside evidence of LDS coercion and retaliation. [4–6]
December 1838	Smith's prison letter disputes accusations and disowns Avard's teachings.	A near-contemporary response from an accused leader, not an independent acquittal. [7]
1850	Violence around Fort Utah, discussed in the source packet and Church essay.	Settlement, Native dispossession, and leadership decisions require attention beyond emigrant history. [1–2]
September 21, 1856	Published report of Young preaching about a sinner's own blood and forgiveness.	Examine what was taught separately from claims about particular killings. [8]
September 1857	The Utah War crisis and the Mountain Meadows attacks, culminating September 11.	Local militia and ecclesiastical authority intersected in the murder of emigrants. [11,14]
September 10, 1857	Young's reply to Haight tells settlers to let the emigrants proceed peacefully; it arrived after the killings.	Relevant evidence against a direct-order allegation, with limits on what it establishes. [12]

Date	Record or event	Investigative significance
1875-1877	Lee's trials, conviction, and execution; Young's 1875 deposition.	Separate courtroom outcomes from the full distribution of historical responsibility. [13–14]
2007 onward	Public LDS condemnation, regret over Paiute blame, and continued Native testimony.	Later acknowledgment and remembrance are evidence of later responses. [15–16]

Exhibit one Persecution and retaliation

The Missouri evidence

Governor Lilburn Boggs's October 27, 1838 order directed that Mormons be treated as enemies and either exterminated or driven from Missouri if necessary. The Missouri State Archives preserves the document. Whatever arguments surrounded the conflict, the order itself is direct evidence of state action targeting a religious community. Its language should be read in the actual document, not softened into an ordinary instruction to prosecute individual offenders. [4]

Three days later, attackers killed seventeen Latter-day Saints at Hawn's Mill. The Church's historical account also notes that some evidence suggests the attackers had not learned of Boggs's order. Sequence alone therefore does not prove that this particular attack was carried out in obedience to that order. That qualification concerns the chain of causation, not whether the victims were murdered. [5]

The correct Christian response to this evidence is to acknowledge the wrong. Disagreement with Smith's religious claims cannot turn attacks on families into legitimate evangelism. Nor should later LDS violence be used retroactively to justify what was done to earlier LDS victims.

The Danites and disputed authority

The Joseph Smith Papers presents a Danite constitution transmitted through Sampson Avard's November 1838 testimony. Its introduction identifies a serious difficulty: Avard cooperated with prosecutors and received immunity. Smith's journal supports awareness of Avard and some Danite activity; Avard's specific assertions about approval of the constitution face evidential challenges. An interested witness may possess real information while also shifting blame. [6]

Smith's December 16 prison letter disputed accusations and rejected authorization of Avard's teachings. The surviving text is a transmitted copy, with variant versions discussed by its editors. It is evidence of Smith's response, not a neutral account from outside the dispute. [7]

The research packet also treats intimidation, retaliatory raids, and the burning and theft of opponents' property. Those allegations should be investigated event by event. Describing a movement as defensive does not establish that every action was defensive. Describing an organization as secretive does not prove that every later frontier crime was its work. [1]

Assessment: persecution and retaliation can coexist in one history. Responsibility for a particular raid requires more than a general accusation; an asserted need to protect a community does not authorize threats against dissenters or attacks on unrelated civilians.

Exhibit two Native neighbors and violent preaching

Whose experience defines the frontier?

The packet and Church essay describe the killing of a Native man known as Old Bishop, escalating conflict near Fort Utah, and Young's authorization of a campaign in 1850. This case reports that account with attribution. It does not claim a fresh inspection of the original military orders, a complete casualty count, or a final resolution of tribal identification in those records. Those matters need a dedicated documentary and Native historical review. [1–2]

The National Park Service's account of Southern Paiute survival describes settlement on essential hunting and gathering land, livestock damage to food plants, and reduced access to cultivation near water. That makes displacement part of the evidence, rather than merely scenery surrounding settler hardship. Its broad account does not identify the perpetrator of each individual death. [17]

Historical judgment should therefore ask who lost food, land, security, and the power to obtain redress. An account centered entirely on settlers' fears can omit the fears their settlement created for other people. Likewise, a general claim of comparatively friendly relations needs a defined comparison and evidence; it cannot excuse a particular killing. Different Native peoples must not be treated as one interchangeable group.

What the published sermon says

In the published report of Young's September 21, 1856 sermon, some sins are described as requiring the offender's own blood for forgiveness. The discussion explicitly connects a person's bloodshed with atonement; it cannot responsibly be reduced to a generic appeal for enthusiastic repentance. That is a claim about the printed teaching. It is not evidence that every alleged blood-atonement execution occurred. [8]

There is also a transmission question. The Church's explanation of the Journal of Discourses says the reports sometimes contain inaccuracies and are not, by themselves, authoritative statements of current doctrine. This caution should prevent claims that every printed sentence is an authenticated verbatim recording. It does not make the published sermon disappear as historical evidence. [9]

The current official Religion vs. Violence page recognizes the earlier idea, places forceful preaching in its rhetorical setting, and states that blood atonement is not Church doctrine. It affirms redemption through Jesus Christ. Historical teaching and current rejection must both be represented. [10]

Assessment: threatening religious language can matter even when a specific command to kill is unproved. The strength of its connection to any

particular crime must still be demonstrated. This case does not establish that Mountain Meadows was a ritual execution performed to redeem the emigrants' sins.

Exhibit three Mountain Meadows and responsibility

What is established

In 1857, a federal military expedition was approaching Utah amid conflict between territorial and national authorities. Memories of earlier persecution helped make the prospect frightening for Latter-day Saints. The research packet treats that crisis as context for hostility toward outsiders; it does not make a passing wagon train responsible for the decisions of federal officials. [1]

In September 1857, emigrants traveling from Arkansas toward California were attacked in southern Utah. After a siege, a promise of protection was used to bring them out from their wagons. Approximately 120 people were killed; seventeen small children survived. Local Latter-day Saint militia leaders and participants were central to the crime. These broad facts appear in the Church's historical account and the Utah State Archives account of the Lee case. [11,14]

This was the killing of people who had been induced to surrender, not simply a battle between two armies. Rumors, arguments over supplies, or threatening remarks attributed to individual travelers cannot justify murdering families. The distinction remains even if particular details of the approach, conversations, or numbers need further examination.

The Church account identifies Isaac Haight's intertwined church and militia leadership and acknowledges deliberate deception. It also describes an effort to place all responsibility on Paiutes. Calling the perpetrators merely unrelated private citizens would conceal the institutional positions involved. At the same time, their positions alone do not establish an order from Church headquarters. [11]

The September 10 letter

Young's reply to Haight told settlers not to interfere with the emigrants and to allow them to leave peacefully. The letter also discussed the Indians as potentially acting on their own and urged preserving good relations with them. The passage is available in Richard E. Turley's published account, which identifies the letterbook record. This case checked that published transcription; it does not claim independent inspection of the archival letterbook. [12]

The instruction against interference is significant evidence against treating a direct order from Young to murder this train as an established fact. The reported late arrival also explains why it could not prevent the completed crime. But one outgoing letter cannot establish everything Young previously knew, everything another leader said orally, or the adequacy of the later investigation. Those are separate propositions requiring their own evidence. [12]

In his July 30, 1875 deposition, Young said he had received the communication and answered Haight; he also said the incoming communication could not be found after a search. A later deposition from a person whose conduct is at issue needs critical evaluation. The missing incoming letter limits reconstruction of what Haight actually disclosed. It does not license inventing its contents in either direction. [13]

Accountability after the crime

Utah State Archives describes Lee's first trial in 1875 ending without a verdict, followed by conviction at his second trial and execution in 1877. Its account highlights the changed prosecution emphasis. Lee's conviction establishes a legal outcome concerning Lee. The absence of additional convictions does not establish that all other participants or superiors were innocent. [14]

Historical responsibility needs several questions rather than one all-or-nothing verdict: Who attacked? Who ordered locally? Who knew beforehand? Who encouraged a climate of hostility? Who concealed

evidence afterward? Who later had power to pursue accountability? Answering one question does not automatically answer the others.

Exhibit four Paiute testimony and later acknowledgment

The KUED documentary We Shall Remain: The Paiute includes Native voices challenging the accusation of Paiute participation. Glen Rogers recounts his grandmother's account placing the killing on white people. Other comments emphasize oral transmission and reject a history that repeatedly assigns their people blame. These are direct records of later testimony and inherited memory, not newly discovered 1857 eyewitness depositions. [15]

The difference in source form matters. A written accusation by an implicated settler has no automatic advantage in honesty over a Native oral tradition. An oral account also needs attention to transmission, specificity, and corroboration. Fair investigation examines both without presuming that access to a clerk or newspaper makes one community truthful and the other unreliable.

In September 2007, Henry B. Eyring, speaking for the First Presidency, condemned the killings as incompatible with Christian conduct. He expressed regret for the massacre and for the Paiutes' having borne principal blame, acknowledged dispute about their involvement, and described local church, civic, and military responsibility. Those are substantial institutional acknowledgments. They should neither be omitted nor converted into a claim that all disputed historical questions were thereby resolved. [16]

The conclusion warranted here is carefully bounded: the old narrative making Paiutes solely or principally responsible is indefensible on the reviewed evidence; the identity and actions of every possible Native participant are not resolved by this case. No tribe, band, or present-day descendant should receive collective guilt.

Remembering victims requires more than allocating blame. Families lost people whose lives cannot be reduced to evidence in an argument about

religion. Later acknowledgment is morally meaningful, while remaining distinct from timely prevention, prosecution, or full restitution. Reconciliation should never be made conditional on forgetting.

Assessing the principal accounts

Witness group	What it can establish	Important limitation
Official orders and correspondence	A preserved instruction, its date, and the information its wording reveals.	Survival may be incomplete; instructions do not establish compliance or all prior knowledge. [4,12]
Avard and Smith	Conflicting near-contemporary claims about authority and conduct.	Avard had prosecutorial incentives; Smith was defending himself and his movement. [6–7]
Published sermon reporters	Teaching publicly circulated under a leader's name.	A printed report is not an audio recording or automatic proof of present doctrine. [8–9]
Young's 1875 deposition	His later answers about communication and missing records.	Delay, memory, and personal interests must be considered. [13]
Lee trial records and their archival description	Court proceedings and Lee's legal outcome.	A conviction of one person is not a complete historical verdict about everyone. [14]
Paiute interviewees	Their community's remembered history and response to inherited accusation.	Later oral transmission requires evaluation; it cannot be dismissed merely because it is oral. [15]
Modern Church statements	Current acknowledgment, interpretation, and doctrinal position.	Institutional hindsight is not an independent contemporary witness to 1857. [10,16]

Young children who survived Mountain Meadows must also be treated with care. Survival does not mean each child observed every stage or could identify every perpetrator. This case does not present seventeen surviving children as seventeen detailed, independent accounts of the command chain.

Nor does it claim to have read every deposition in Lee's case file. The procedural overview and specifically identified Young deposition page were checked. A comprehensive prosecution-history study would require the complete file, testimony comparisons, exhibits, and relevant records outside it.

The strongest LDS argument

A thoughtful LDS response can begin with an important concession: Christians do not infer that Christ is false whenever people who profess him commit grave sin. Persecution created understandable fear, some members violated their own scriptures, and a distinction remains between the gospel professed and the crime committed. Modern LDS condemnation of the massacre and rejection of blood atonement make this an actual position to engage, rather than an invented defense. [3,10,16]

That argument has real force against sweeping claims that every LDS person is violent or that one atrocity logically disproves every restoration claim. It also rightly resists treating fear as a peculiarly LDS human weakness.

The unresolved question is how to evaluate leaders' teaching and the operation of authority, not merely the existence of sinful followers. If salvation language legitimizes a person's bloodshed, or church office helps organize intimidation, those features deserve direct examination. Calling everything human imperfection can become a way to avoid identifying which teaching was wrong and why.

A fair Christian response should therefore grant the distinction between Christ and misconduct, then ask how the community recognizes error, corrects it, protects dissenters, and tests leaders by Scripture. The same questions belong in Christian churches.

Competing explanations

Frontier violence and community survival

Fear, weak protection, resource conflict, and memories of persecution form a plausible setting for escalation. This explanation draws attention to pressures without requiring that every participant acted from a carefully developed theology. Its limit is moral and evidential: context cannot explain away the choice to deceive and kill surrendered civilians, and it cannot replace evidence about who made that choice.

Local initiative within concentrated authority

Local leaders could exercise religious, civic, and militia power at once. This model helps explain how obedience to a familiar religious authority could be redirected into collective crime. It fits acknowledged local responsibility without requiring an authenticated central order. Its danger is using the word local to make institutional involvement disappear.

Wider responsibility without a proven direct order

A superior might bear responsibility for dangerous teaching, failures of supervision, or later concealment even without issuing the final command. Each allegation requires separate evidence. This case does not establish all such allegations against Young, and it does not infer that the absence of a demonstrated command settles them all in his favor.

A deliberately organized religious conspiracy

A stronger claim would assert an advance plan directed from the top, with the massacre as its intended result. That requires evidence connecting the specific plan, its communication, and the intended crime. General hostility, later evasiveness, or the existence of militia discipline is insufficient by itself. The reviewed record does not establish an authenticated direct order from Young to massacre this train.

These explanations overlap. Social pressure, personal agency, religious language, and institutional power can operate together. A satisfactory

account should explain the evidence without turning a plausible inference into a recovered conversation or an undiscovered document.

Motives benefits and costs

Fear of exposure, loyalty to a community, desire to retain authority, and attempts to escape punishment are possible motives worth testing. They are investigative hypotheses, not permission to claim knowledge of every person's heart. The relevant question is whether a source connects a proposed motive to an actual decision.

The same discipline applies to later narrators. An accused participant may shift blame upward or outward. An institutional account may protect a founder's reputation. A critic may select the most incriminating version. Descendants may seek acknowledgment of suffering long minimized. These possibilities tell us what to examine; none automatically makes a witness dishonest.

Costs matter as well. A person who speaks against a powerful group may risk belonging and reputation; someone who maintains loyalty may sincerely believe that loyalty is faithful. Neither sacrifice nor sincerity makes a claim true by itself. The investigator still needs evidence.

The largest costs in this case were borne by victims. Their suffering should not be treated as a rhetorical benefit for either side of a religious debate.

A biblical assessment

Peacemaking applies when people are afraid

Matthew 5:9 honors peacemakers, and verses 43-48 command love for enemies. The command becomes most searching when an opponent seems threatening. Fear does not erase the obligation to recognize another person's humanity. LDS readers can affirm these passages too; the disagreement is not over whether Jesus used the language of peace. [18]

Romans 12:17-21 forbids personal vengeance and directs believers to do good even to an enemy. Romans 13:1-10 then addresses governing authority

and its responsibility toward wrongdoing. Christians differ about pacifism, military service, and defensive force. Those differences do not require treating a false promise of safety followed by civilian murder as an acceptable form of protection. [19]

It would also be a misuse of Romans 13 to assume that an official title sanctifies every official act. The passage describes authority serving good, then connects obedience with the duty of love. Religious office, militia rank, and state power do not make cruelty righteous.

Christ's sacrifice and blood atonement

Hebrews 10:10-18 presents Christ's offering as decisive and sufficient for the people sanctified through him. First John 1:7 locates cleansing from sin in Jesus' blood. From this case's evangelical perspective, the proposal that an offender's blood must provide an additional saving sacrifice conflicts with that account. Civil punishment and the saving atonement of Christ are different categories. [20]

Hebrews also warns severely about deliberate sin in verses 26-31. That warning does not appoint believers to create a second sacrifice out of the sinner's body. Judgment is not an instruction to complete Christ's work through religious killing. Nor does this theological argument require denying that crimes have consequences or that repentance includes truthful accountability.

This criticism concerns the historical teaching examined above. The current Church statement places redemption in Christ and rejects blood atonement as doctrine. Fair comparison must say so. The remaining question concerns the earlier teaching's character, transmission, and authority, rather than pretending that every present-day LDS member endorses it. [10]

Teachers carry responsibility for words

James 3:1 warns of greater judgment for teachers, and verses 13-18 contrast envy and strife with peaceable wisdom. That supplies a reason to examine religious rhetoric even where no direct criminal command is proved. A teacher should consider what fearful hearers may understand themselves to be authorized to do. This is a biblical application, not a claim that a verse reconstructs a historical chain of command. [21]

The standard must apply to our own Christian communities. We should not dismiss similar wrongdoing among people sharing our label as mere exceptions while treating LDS wrongdoing as the essence of every LDS person. Scripture is a standard for judgment, not a way to exempt our side from it.

The positive Christian invitation

The aim of Christian witness is to make Christ known. Ephesians 2:8-10 describes salvation by grace through faith, resulting in good works. First Peter 3:15-16 requires a reasoned answer given with meekness and a good conscience. A conversation about history should be able to move toward the trustworthiness of Jesus, forgiveness, and life under his authority without using another person's family history as humiliation. [22]

Findings and confidence

Finding	Confidence	Reason and boundary
Early LDS persecution was real.	High for the episodes examined.	A preserved state order and the Hawn's Mill record support specific conclusions. They do not validate every later memory. [4–5]

Finding	Confidence	Reason and boundary
Historical blood-atonement preaching deserves direct scrutiny.	High for the published report; wording has transmission limits.	The report connects a sinner's blood with forgiveness. Its status differs from current official doctrine. [8–10]
Mountain Meadows involved deliberate killing under local LDS leadership.	High.	Church and state archival accounts converge on the central crime and local responsibility. [11,14]
A direct order from Young to massacre the train is proved.	Not established here.	The peaceful-passage reply is relevant contrary evidence; the complete communication record is not available in this review. [12–13]
Paiutes alone or principally caused the massacre.	Rejected on the reviewed evidence.	Local LDS responsibility and the history of blame-shifting are acknowledged; Native testimony challenges the inherited accusation. [11,15–16]
Every individual's role and every superior's knowledge are resolved.	Not established here.	Records, interests, delay, and missing communications limit reconstruction.
Modern LDS teaching endorses blood atonement.	Contradicted by the current statement.	The Church expressly rejects it as doctrine. [10]

Overall assessment

The reviewed history contains both serious wrongs against Latter-day Saints and serious wrongs committed by Latter-day Saints, including people exercising religious authority. An honest account should acknowledge both without making either a defense of the other.

Mountain Meadows is not merely an allegation manufactured by opponents. The principal crime and local LDS responsibility are well supported. Some further claims about orders, prior knowledge, and individual participation need more qualified conclusions. Qualification should sharpen responsibility where the evidence permits it, not dissolve responsibility altogether.

The historical blood-atonement teaching also creates a direct theological issue. From this project's Christian perspective, an offender's death cannot supply a saving sacrifice alongside Christ's finished offering. The present Church's rejection of the teaching is relevant evidence of its current position, while the earlier preaching remains a legitimate subject of investigation.

These conclusions do not prove every religious claim true or false. They do require us to test authority, refuse collective guilt, honor the victims, and speak accurately even where an exaggerated accusation would make our argument easier.

Read compare and discuss

Questions for a group or family

1. Read the Boggs order alongside the Hawn's Mill account. What is established by each source? What causal connection still needs evidence?
2. What changes when an account includes Native access to food and land as well as settler fears?
3. How do you distinguish a leader's teaching, a specific order, personal participation, and later concealment?
4. Why does the September 10 letter matter? Which questions can it answer, and which remain separate?
5. What would it take to assess an accusation against a specific Paiute person without placing guilt on a whole people?
6. Compare the historical sermon, the current Church position, and Hebrews 10. Where is the agreement, and where is the disagreement?

7. When have Christians used the language of obedience or loyalty to avoid accountability? What safeguards would James 3 require?
8. What would honoring victims look like beyond winning a debate?

A conversation with an LDS friend

Begin with permission and shared concern: I have been reading the Church's own discussion of peace and violence. Would you be comfortable looking at one part together? I want to understand how you think about it.

Start with a source you can both inspect. A useful question is: How do you distinguish a leader's mistaken opinion from teaching people were expected to receive as spiritually authoritative? Listen before offering your own distinction.

For the theological conversation, you might ask: Could we read Hebrews 10 together and talk about what Christ's sacrifice accomplishes? Explain positively why you trust Jesus for forgiveness. Do not require your friend to defend every historical leader before allowing that person to speak about faith.

If you discuss Mountain Meadows, acknowledge LDS persecution without bargaining away the emigrants' deaths or Native suffering. State plainly what the evidence supports, say when something is unresolved, and recognize current condemnation where it exists. A friend may know this history well, may be learning it, or may find it painful. Respectful witness makes room for an honest response.

Accuracy notes and further research

- **Scope:** the packet, physical PDF pages 196-230, guided selection. This is a focused study, not a census of nineteenth-century violence or a complete Fort Utah investigation. [1]
- **Source types:** orders, copied letters, sermon reports, and later depositions have different strengths. Modern institutional histories and archive introductions remain interpretations, even when they link original records.

- **Document access:** Young's September 10 reply was checked through a published transcription. The archival original, complete Lee trial file, and unpublished Church holdings were not independently audited. [12–14]
- **Count and chronology:** approximately 120 deaths and seventeen surviving children follow the reviewed accounts. The attacks culminated September 11, 1857. A later proclamation should not be placed before the massacre without checking its date.
- **Attribution:** no direct massacre order from Young is established here. Rhetoric, earlier knowledge, supervision, and later response remain separate questions.
- **Native evidence:** oral testimony was read alongside accusations against Paiutes. Specific identities and actions require further work; Native people have their own evidence and must not receive collective blame. [15,17]
- **Teaching and action:** published blood-atonement preaching does not prove a particular execution or the motive for Mountain Meadows. Historical wording, reporting accuracy, current status, and biblical evaluation remain distinct. [8–10]
- **Further review:** compare the complete trial testimony, letterbook image, militia records, Native oral histories, and specialist Fort Utah and Mountain Meadows studies before a book treatment.
- **Moral consistency:** present-day members do not inherit personal guilt for historical crimes. Use the same evidence standards for other religions and Christian institutions.

Sources and reading

The source register records what was used and how. Web texts were checked November 8, 2026, local project date. Scripture references use the KJV unless a distinct LDS text is identified. Commentary in linked editions is distinguished from the underlying text. The supplied compilation is a research aid, not independent corroboration of the sources it summarizes.

[1] Supplied research packet. LDS Gospel Topics Essays .pdf, 366 physical pages, Peace and Violence packet at physical pages 196-230. Read as the project's source inventory, claim breakdown, Christian comparison, and research questions. This file is supplied project material, not a new primary record of the events.

[2] Official LDS historical framing. Peace and Violence among 19th-Century Latter-day Saints, Gospel Topics Essays. Used for the Church's own framing and the attributed Fort Utah summary. Its conclusions are distinguished from contemporary records and independent confirmation.

[3] LDS peace and defense text. Doctrine and Covenants 98, especially verses 16, 23-48. The surrounding discussion of injury, war, and forgiveness qualifies an isolated use of the peace command.

[4] Missouri executive order. Lilburn W. Boggs, October 27, 1838, archival scan, Missouri State Archives. Compare the contemporary copied text in Joseph Smith's Letterbook 2, page 34. Direct documentary evidence of the order; it does not by itself establish the Hawn's Mill attackers' knowledge.

[5] Hawn's Mill account. Hawn's Mill Massacre, Church History Topics. Used for the October 30 event, seventeen deaths, and its caution about assuming the attackers knew Boggs's order. A modern institutional historical account, not itself an 1838 eyewitness affidavit.

[6] Danite constitution and source criticism. Appendix 2: Constitution of the Society of the Daughter of Zion, circa Late June 1838, Joseph Smith Papers, historical introduction and document edition. Used for the document's transmission through Avard, his incentives, and the limits of specific claims about Smith's approval. Editorial conclusions and the transmitted constitution are different forms of evidence.

[7] Smith's response. Letter to the Church in Caldwell County, Missouri, December 16, 1838, Joseph Smith Papers, source note and historical introduction. A surviving copied letter with variant textual traditions; used as evidence of Smith's defense and rejection of authorization of Avard's teachings.

[8] Historical blood-atonement sermon. Brigham Young, September 21, 1856, published in Journal of Discourses, volume 4, online sermon transcription, hosted by the Joseph Smith Foundation. A historical published report, not an authenticated audio record or current official doctrinal statement. The host is distinct from the Joseph Smith Papers.

[9] Status of the sermon collection. Journal of Discourses, official Church explanation. Used for the modern assessment of reporting inaccuracies, the compilation's history, and its lack of independent authority as a statement of current doctrine.

[10] Current LDS position. Religion vs. Violence, Topics and Questions (2025), section on blood atonement. Direct evidence of the present official rejection of that teaching and affirmation of redemption through Christ; its retrospective rhetorical interpretation is identified as an interpretation.

[11] Official Mountain Meadows narrative. Mountain Meadows Massacre, Church History Topics. Used for the main narrative, local leadership, deception, death and survivor counts, and the effort to shift blame. Its historical conclusions are not treated as unanimous agreement by every historian.

[12] Young's reply to Haight. Brigham Young to Isaac C. Haight, September 10, 1857, Letterbook volume 3, pages 827-828, Brigham Young Office Files, Church History Library, as transcribed in Richard E. Turley Jr., The Mountain Meadows Massacre, originally Ensign, September 2007, Communication section and note 6. The quoted letter passage and reported late arrival were checked in this publication; no inspection of the original letterbook is claimed.

[13] Young's later deposition. July 30, 1875 deposition, page 6 of 8, Utah State Archives transcription project on FromThePage. Questions 13-16 concern the communication from Haight, Young's inability to find it, and his reply. This specific page was checked; it is not a claim of full trial-file review.

[14] Lee proceedings. Mountain Meadows Massacre in the Records, Utah Division of Archives and Records Service, September 9, 2022. Identifies Second District Court criminal case files, series 24291, case 31, and describes the two trials. Used for procedural history and the legal outcome, not as proof that Lee alone was responsible.

[15] Recorded Paiute perspectives. KUED, We Shall Remain: The Paiute, transcript hosted by Arizona PBS, 2009 episode listing. The Mountain Meadows segment includes Glen Rogers's inherited account and comments rejecting Paiute involvement. Direct evidence of recorded community perspectives and oral transmission; interviewees are not presented as 1857 eyewitnesses.

[16] Institutional acknowledgment. Henry B. Eyring, 150th Anniversary of Mountain Meadows Massacre, September 11, 2007. Remarks for the First Presidency, including condemnation, regret, local responsibility, and the disputed extent of Paiute involvement. A primary source for the 2007 response.

[17] Native settlement context. Survival of the Southern Paiute, U.S. National Park Service. Used for effects on land, water, food resources, and the importance of Native history beyond the massacre. A public-history synthesis; its population estimates are not independently recalculated or used here as precise casualty totals.

[18] Peacemaking and enemies. Matthew 5, especially verses 9 and 43-48. Read within the Sermon on the Mount; the ethical application is the project's stated Christian assessment.

[19] Vengeance and governing authority. Romans 12:17-21 and Romans 13:1-10. Read together rather than assuming that the condemnation of vengeance resolves every Christian debate about defensive force.

[20] Christ's sacrifice and cleansing. Hebrews 10, especially verses 10-18 and 26-31, and 1 John 1:7. The argument distinguishes Christ's saving offering, divine judgment, repentance, and civil consequences.

[21] Teachers and peaceable wisdom. James 3, especially verses 1 and 13-18. Grounds the Christian assessment of teachers' words and the obligation to seek peace without pretending to identify a historical perpetrator from a biblical passage.

[22] Grace and respectful witness. Ephesians 2:8-10 and 1 Peter 3:15-16. Ground the positive invitation to faith in Christ and the manner of Christian conversation.

Collection notes

Case File 008 follows Mother in Heaven and precedes Plural Marriage in Kirtland and Nauvoo. The LDS collection begins with 00 and continues through Cases 001-012, followed by the separate Christian conversation guide. Later cases and the guide require their own completion and publication checks.